SAT Reading & Writing — Targeted Practice Set

48 questions | Module 2 (higher-difficulty) calibration | Words in Context + Standard English Conventions

How this set is built

Every item follows Bluebook formatting: a short passage with one blank, a single directive question, and four choices. Difficulty is calibrated to the **second, harder module** — vocabulary items draw their answers from lower-frequency registers, and the distractors are near-misses rather than obvious errors.

The 32 grammar items are weighted deliberately. Twelve of them (Part 2A) drill the single pattern that gives the most trouble: **a transitional adverb sitting at a sentence boundary**, where the choices differ over whether the adverb closes the first clause or opens the second, and what punctuation belongs with it. Several of those items are built so that the material after the blank is *not* an independent clause — which is what makes "start a new sentence with *However*" the wrong reflex.

The one habit worth building

On every boundary question, do this before looking at the choices: **cover the blank and test each side separately.** Can the words to the left stand alone as a sentence? Can the words to the right? Two independent sides means you need a period or a semicolon, never a comma. If the right side cannot stand alone, no terminal punctuation may appear in the blank at all, and any adverb in the blank is parenthetical — commas on both sides.

Suggested timing: 55 minutes for all 48, or split into two sittings of roughly 25 minutes each. Answers with full explanations begin on the answer-key page.

Part 1 · Words in Context — 16 questions

Each passage is followed by the same directive. Predict a word in your own language before reading the choices; then eliminate any choice that fails to match the *direction* the passage sets (agreement vs. contrast) before weighing shades of meaning.

1.

Though critics long dismissed Hilma af Klint's abstract canvases as the eccentric byproduct of her interest in mysticism, later scholars have argued that her work _____ European modernism rather than derived from it: she completed her first fully nonrepresentational paintings in 1906, several years before Kandinsky.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) presaged
B) mimicked
C) supplanted
D) chronicled

2.

Marine biologist Kakani Katija studies jellyfish locomotion with instruments so sensitive that even minute vibrations from a passing ship can _____ the data; her team therefore takes measurements only inside a chamber isolated from external motion.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) replicate
B) extrapolate
C) corroborate
D) vitiate

3.

Toni Morrison's prose is often described as _____: a single sentence can carry the weight of an entire family history, compressing decades of inheritance and loss into a handful of words.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) ornate
B) desultory
C) discursive
D) capacious

4.

Economist Esther Duflo has cautioned against _____ conclusions from a randomized trial run in a single village, noting that an intervention's success often depends on local conditions that do not obtain elsewhere.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) circumscribing
B) extrapolating
C) corroborating
D) jettisoning

5.

The senator's closing remarks were praised above all for their _____: in under twelve minutes she answered every objection her opponents had raised over the course of a monthlong campaign.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) candor
B) bombast
C) economy
D) levity

6.

Far from being _____, the reef's recovery has proved halting and uneven: some sections rebounded within a decade, while others show almost no new growth after twice that span.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) inexorable
B) precarious
C) belated
D) anomalous

7.

Choreographer Pina Bausch was famously _____ in rehearsal, discarding entire sequences her dancers had spent weeks perfecting if a single gesture struck her as false.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) exacting
B) diffident
C) mercurial
D) genial

8.

The manuscript's marginalia, long dismissed as _____ scribbles, turned out to constitute a systematic index that the scribe had used to cross-reference passages across three volumes.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) illegible
B) apocryphal
C) idiosyncratic
D) desultory

9.

Physicist Chien-Shiung Wu's 1956 experiment _____ what had been treated as an inviolable law of nature, demonstrating that parity is not conserved in weak nuclear interactions.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) codified
B) confuted
C) reiterated
D) presupposed

10.

Although the committee's report was ostensibly neutral, its _____ praise for the proposal — one sentence of tepid approval buried in ninety pages — signaled unmistakable disapproval.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) perfunctory
B) unstinting
C) trenchant
D) fulsome

11.

Linguist Marianne Mithun argues that early descriptions of Indigenous North American languages were _____ by their authors' expectations: accustomed to Indo-European structures, these researchers mistook unfamiliar patterns for an absence of pattern.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) circumscribed
B) supplanted
C) colored
D) vindicated

12.

The novel's narrator is _____ about matters of consequence: she catalogs the color of every teacup in the house but never once explains why her sister vanished.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) candid
B) meticulous
C) reticent
D) garrulous

13.

Rather than _____ the contradictions among her sources, the historian foregrounds them, treating each discrepancy as evidence of how differently the same event was experienced.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) elucidating
B) reconciling
C) amplifying
D) documenting

14.

Critics of the redevelopment plan called it _____, pointing out that its projected timeline assumed thirty consecutive years of uninterrupted funding and unbroken political goodwill.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) draconian
B) opaque
C) quixotic
D) parsimonious

15.

Once _____, the technique is now routine: nearly every laboratory in the field runs the assay that Ochoa's group spent years struggling to persuade anyone to attempt.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) rudimentary
B) provisional
C) ubiquitous
D) heterodox

16.

Less a considered judgment than a concession to _____, the board's decision was reached in the final ten minutes of a meeting that had already run two hours past its scheduled end.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

A) unanimity
B) expedience
C) acrimony
D) prescience

Part 2 · Standard English Conventions — 32 questions

2A. Sentence boundaries and transitional-adverb placement (12)

The core set. In each item, decide which clause the adverb belongs to before you decide on punctuation.

17.

For most of the twentieth century, physicians treated peptic ulcers with bland diets and stress management. Barry Marshall's experiments overturned that consensus _____ he demonstrated that the great majority of ulcers are caused by *Helicobacter pylori* infection.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) entirely in fact,
B) entirely, in fact
C) entirely, in fact,
D) entirely. In fact,

18.

Kelp forests along the California coast collapsed within a few years of the sea otters' disappearance. The connection escaped notice _____ ecologists identified it only after observing urchins, released from predation, grazing the kelp down to bare rock.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) at first indeed,
B) at first indeed
C) at first, indeed,
D) at first. Indeed,

19.

Voyager 1 has been returning data for nearly five decades. Its plutonium power source is now close to exhausted _____ engineers expect the final instrument to fall silent before 2030.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) though. Consequently,
B) though consequently,
C) though, consequently
D) though, consequently,

20.

The Antikythera mechanism's gear ratios encode the Metonic cycle with remarkable accuracy. No comparable device survives from anywhere in the ancient world _____ the mechanism's sophistication went unrecognized for decades after its recovery.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) . Unsurprisingly,
B) unsurprisingly,
C) , unsurprisingly,
D) , unsurprisingly

21.

Two of the three prototypes fractured under load testing. The third held _____ engineers had replaced the titanium sleeve with a nickel-based alloy.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) . However, only after
B) , however, only after
C) ; however only after
D) however; only after

22.

The eruption buried the settlement under four meters of ash within hours. Archaeologists consider the site exceptionally well preserved _____ precisely because the destruction was so sudden.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) , ironically;
B) . Ironically,
C) , ironically,
D) ; ironically

23.

Wind turbines kill far fewer birds per unit of energy generated than coal-fired plants do. That mortality is _____ concentrated along migratory corridors, where poorly sited turbines intersect established flight paths.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) ; however, heavily
B) however heavily
C) , however. Heavily
D) , however, heavily

24.

Only two copies of the 1516 edition are known to survive. Both are held in private collections _____ which is why scholars have had to rely on a nineteenth-century facsimile.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) ; unfortunately,
B) unfortunately
C) , unfortunately,
D) . Unfortunately,

25.

Three factors made the 1918 influenza pandemic unusually lethal _____ troop movements that carried the virus across continents, wartime censorship that suppressed early warnings, and a strain that struck healthy young adults hardest.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) :
B) ,
C) ;
D) — namely —

26.

The mission's most fragile instrument _____ a spectrometer cooled to within a few degrees of absolute zero — survived a launch that destroyed two of its protective housings.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) :
B) —
C) ,
D) ;

27.

Because the marine reserve prohibits every form of extraction, including recreational line fishing _____ the reef's fish populations have rebounded to roughly seventy percent of their 1980 levels.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) :
B) ,
C) ;
D) .

28.

The vaccine's measured efficacy declines noticeably after six months _____ a booster restores protection to near-initial levels within two weeks.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) , nevertheless,
B) , nevertheless
C) ; nevertheless,
D) nevertheless,

2B. Other punctuation and boundaries (6)

Colons, dashes, supplements, lists, and the frequently correct answer of no punctuation at all.

29.

The physicist _____ who shared the 1963 Nobel Prize for her model of nuclear shell structure, spent most of her career in unpaid or unsalaried positions.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) Maria Goeppert Mayer;
B) Maria Goeppert Mayer —
C) Maria Goeppert Mayer,
D) Maria Goeppert Mayer

30.

Recent studies of the effects of chronic urban noise on nesting songbird populations _____ that several species raise the pitch of their calls to be heard above traffic.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) suggest,
B) , suggest
C) suggesting
D) suggest

31.

The exhibition draws on holdings in three cities: Lima, Peru _____ Quito, Ecuador; and La Paz, Bolivia.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) —
B) ;
C) ,
D) :

32.

Longer growing seasons, milder winters, more frequent midsummer droughts _____ all of these follow from the same rise in mean global temperature.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) —
B) :
C) ;
D) ,

33.

The 1970 census undercounted urban residents by an estimated two percent _____ the 1980 census corrected that methodology but introduced fresh errors of its own.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) , and
B) ; and
C) ,
D) and

34.

The team analyzed sediment cores collected _____ from four subarctic lakes over the course of a single field season.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) ,
B) *(no punctuation)*
C) ;
D) :

2C. Verbs, agreement, pronouns, modifiers, and possessives (11)

35.

The array of seismic sensors mounted along the fault line _____ ground motion at intervals of one millisecond.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) have recorded
B) record
C) records
D) are recording

36.

Neither the principal investigator nor the graduate students _____ able to explain the anomaly when it first appeared in the data.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) were
B) has been
C) is
D) was

37.

By the time the survey team reached the summit in 1953, three earlier expeditions _____ within a few hundred meters of it.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) come
B) have come
C) had come
D) were coming

38.

The ethics committee released _____ findings three months later than it had promised.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) it's
B) their
C) they're
D) its

39.

The long professional rivalry between Ada and _____ shaped the direction of the laboratory for more than a decade.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) she
B) her
C) herself
D) hers

40.

Researchers compared the transequatorial migration routes of Arctic terns with _____ of sooty shearwaters.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) them
B) it
C) that
D) those

41.

Weighing less than a paperclip and measuring just over five centimeters from bill to tail, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) the bee hummingbird is the smallest bird alive today.
B) it takes considerable patience to observe the bee hummingbird.
C) the bee hummingbird's nest is smaller than a walnut.
D) researchers have found the bee hummingbird difficult to band.

42.

Having lain buried in oxygen-free mud for more than two thousand years, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) the wooden figures emerged from the trench nearly intact.
B) the excavation revealed wooden figures that were nearly intact.
C) it was surprising that the wooden figures were intact.
D) archaeologists found the wooden figures nearly intact.

43.

Trained as a chemist rather than as a physician, _____

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) malaria nonetheless became the focus of Tu Youyou's life's work.
B) Tu Youyou nonetheless devoted her career to the treatment of malaria.
C) it was malaria that Tu Youyou nonetheless spent her career studying.
D) Tu Youyou's career was nonetheless devoted to the treatment of malaria.

44.

Both _____ notebooks were donated to the university archive after their deaths in the 1930s.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) scientists's
B) scientists'
C) scientist's
D) scientists

45.

The _____ hull was reinforced with iron plating, a modification that added nearly forty tons to its displacement.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

A) vessels's
B) vessels
C) vessel's
D) vessels'

2D. Transitions (3)

Different directive, different task: here the punctuation is already settled and only the logic is in question.

46.

Most nineteenth-century naturalists conducted their scientific arguments by letter, and a single exchange could take months to complete. Darwin's correspondence network was unusually large. _____ he maintained regular written contact with more than two thousand people on five continents.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A) At its height,
B) In fact,
C) Nevertheless,
D) Similarly,

47.

Researchers had expected the compound to reduce joint inflammation within a matter of days. _____ patients showed no measurable change until the fourth week of treatment.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A) Consequently,
B) Moreover,
C) Instead,
D) Similarly,

48.

The 1783 Laki fissure eruption released enough sulfur dioxide to depress Northern Hemisphere temperatures by more than a degree. Widespread crop failures followed across Europe and Japan. _____ the eruption has been proposed as one contributing cause of the famines that preceded the French Revolution.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

A) For this reason,
B) In contrast,
C) Likewise,
D) Nevertheless,

Answer Key and Explanations

Quick-check grid

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
A	**D**	**D**	**B**	**C**	**A**	**A**	**D**	**B**	**A**	**C**	**C**
13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24
B	**C**	**D**	**B**	**D**	**D**	**A**	**A**	**B**	**C**	**D**	**C**
25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32	33	34	35	36
A	**B**	**B**	**C**	**C**	**D**	**B**	**A**	**A**	**B**	**C**	**A**
37	38	39	40	41	42	43	44	45	46	47	48
C	**D**	**B**	**D**	**A**	**A**	**B**	**B**	**C**	**B**	**C**	**A**

Explanations

Part 1 — Words in Context

1. Correct answer: A

Presaged means foreshadowed or came before as a sign of. The colon explains the claim: she painted abstractly *before* Kandinsky, so her work anticipated modernism. (B) *Mimicked* means copied — the exact opposite of "rather than derived from it." (C) *Supplanted* means replaced, but modernism was not displaced. (D) *Chronicled* means recorded, which would require modernism to already exist.

2. Correct answer: D

Vitiate means to spoil or impair the quality of. The team isolates the chamber to prevent something bad from happening to the data. (C) *Corroborate* means to confirm — a positive outcome nobody would guard against. (A) *Replicate* means to reproduce. (B) *Extrapolate* means to project beyond known data; vibrations don't do that.

3. Correct answer: D

Capacious means able to hold a great deal — precisely the point that one sentence "carries the weight of an entire family history." (C) *Discursive* means digressive or rambling, contradicting "compressing." (A) *Ornate* describes decoration, not capacity. (B) *Desultory* means aimless.

4. Correct answer: B

Extrapolating means extending a conclusion beyond the data that support it — exactly the error Duflo warns about. (C) *Corroborating* means confirming, which she would not warn against. (D) *Jettisoning* means discarding. (A) *Circumscribing* means limiting — the opposite of the overreach described.

5. Correct answer: C

Economy here carries its secondary sense: efficient use of means — much accomplished in little space. The clue is "under twelve minutes" versus "a monthlong campaign." (D) *Levity* is humor. (A) *Candor* is frankness — plausible but unsupported; nothing indicates she was unusually blunt. (B) *Bombast* is inflated language, which is not praiseworthy and contradicts the brevity.

6. Correct answer: A

"Far from" signals a contrast with "halting and uneven," so the blank needs a word meaning steady and unstoppable. **Inexorable** fits. (B) *Precarious* means unstable — that agrees with "halting," so no contrast. (C) *Belated* means late, unrelated to evenness. (D) *Anomalous* means atypical.

7. Correct answer: A

Exacting means demanding very high standards — supported by her rejecting whole sequences over one false gesture. (B) *Diffident* means shy or lacking confidence. (C) *Mercurial* means prone to unpredictable mood swings; the text describes consistently high standards, not volatility — this is the trap. (D) *Genial* means friendly.

8. Correct answer: D

Desultory means lacking a plan or method — the direct opposite of the "systematic index" the marks turned out to be. (C) *Idiosyncratic* means peculiar to one person; an index can be idiosyncratic and systematic at once, so it creates no contrast. (A) *Illegible* concerns readability, not organization. (B) *Apocryphal* means of doubtful authenticity.

9. Correct answer: B

Confuted means proved wrong. "Demonstrating that parity is *not* conserved" disproves the supposed law. (A) *Codified* means formally set down. (C) *Reiterated* means repeated. (D) *Presupposed* means assumed in advance — the reverse of testing it.

10. Correct answer: A

Perfunctory means done merely as a formality, without care — matching "one sentence of tepid approval buried in ninety pages." (D) *Fulsome* and (B) *unstinting* both indicate excessive or generous praise, contradicting "tepid." (C) *Trenchant* means incisive and forceful.

11. Correct answer: C

Colored is used in its secondary sense: influenced or biased. The colon explains how the authors' expectations distorted what they recorded. (D) *Vindicated* means justified. (A) *Circumscribed* means restricted in scope — close, but the passage describes misinterpretation, not narrowness. (B) *Supplanted* means replaced.

12. Correct answer: C

Reticent means unwilling to speak about something. The contrast ("but never once explains") applies specifically to "matters of consequence." (B) *Meticulous* describes her handling of trivia, not of consequential matters — this is the trap. (D) *Garrulous* means talkative, which contradicts her silence on the important point. (A) *Candid* means forthcoming, the opposite of what's shown.

13. Correct answer: B

"Rather than" demands the opposite of "foregrounds them." **Reconciling** means smoothing conflicting accounts into agreement. (A) *Elucidating* means clarifying, which is compatible with foregrounding. (C) *Amplifying* means emphasizing — a synonym for foregrounding, so it breaks the contrast. (D) *Documenting* is likewise compatible.

14. Correct answer: C

Quixotic means idealistic to the point of impracticality — fitting a plan that requires thirty flawless years. (D) *Parsimonious* means stingy. (A) *Draconian* means harshly severe. (B) *Opaque* means unclear; the plan's assumptions are stated plainly enough for critics to enumerate.

15. Correct answer: D

Heterodox means departing from accepted practice — which explains why the group had to struggle to persuade anyone to try it. "Once ___ ... now routine" requires a contrast with acceptance. (C) *Ubiquitous* means everywhere, which agrees with "routine" rather than contrasting. (A) *Rudimentary* means undeveloped, which wouldn't explain the resistance. (B) *Provisional* means temporary.

16. Correct answer: B

Expedience is the pursuit of what is convenient rather than what is right or well reasoned — the contrast the sentence sets against "a considered judgment." (A) *Unanimity* describes agreement among voters, which is not opposed to careful deliberation. (C) *Acrimony* means bitterness; nothing indicates conflict. (D) *Prescience* means foresight, which is closer to a considered judgment than opposed to it.

Part 2A — Boundaries and transitional-adverb placement

17. Correct answer: D

Two independent clauses sit on either side of the blank. **"Entirely" belongs to the first sentence** (it modifies "overturned"), and **"In fact," opens the second** — so a period must fall between them. (B) and (C) place only a comma between two independent clauses: comma splice. (A) supplies no boundary punctuation at all: run-on. *Key move:* read the trailing adverb with the clause before it, then ask whether what remains can stand alone. It can, so you need a period or semicolon.

18. Correct answer: D

"At first" completes *The connection escaped notice at first*; "Indeed," introduces the next independent clause. Only a period separates them correctly. (A) and (C) join two complete sentences with a comma — comma splices. (B) supplies no boundary punctuation at all, producing a run-on.

19. Correct answer: A

Here *two* adverbs meet at the boundary. "Though" is a trailing concessive that closes the first sentence — it qualifies the claim that the power source is nearly exhausted. "Consequently," opens the second sentence and introduces the result. A period must fall between them. (C) and (D) join two complete sentences with only a comma — comma splices. (B) supplies no boundary punctuation, producing a run-on. *Key move:* when two adverbs collide at a boundary, assign each one to its own clause *before* choosing punctuation. Once "though" goes left and "consequently" goes right, both sides are complete sentences, and only a period or semicolon will do.

20. Correct answer: A

Both halves are complete sentences, and "unsurprisingly" belongs to the *second* one — it comments on the sophistication going unrecognized, not on the absence of comparable devices. So the period falls before it. (B), (C), and (D) all join two complete sentences with nothing stronger than a comma. *Key move:* ask what the adverb is commenting on. That tells you which side of the break it sits on; the punctuation follows automatically.

21. Correct answer: B

This is the trap to watch for. "Only after engineers had replaced the titanium sleeve" is a **dependent** clause — it cannot stand alone — so no period or semicolon may precede it. "However" is a parenthetical inside one sentence and needs commas on both sides. (A) creates a fragment. (C) and (D) place terminal punctuation before a dependent clause. *Key move:* before you decide where "however" goes, check whether the material after it can survive as its own sentence. If it can't, "however" is parenthetical, not a sentence opener.

22. Correct answer: C

"Precisely because the destruction was so sudden" is a subordinate clause explaining *why* the site is well preserved; it belongs to the same sentence. "Ironically" is parenthetical and takes paired commas. (B) leaves "Ironically, precisely because..." as a fragment. (A) and (D) put a semicolon before material that is not independent.

23. Correct answer: D

The blank sits *inside* a single clause, between "is" and "concentrated." "However" is parenthetical there and needs commas on both sides. (C) severs the verb from its complement and produces a fragment. (A) puts a semicolon after "is," which cannot end a clause. (B) omits the required commas around the parenthetical.

24. Correct answer: C

"Which is why scholars have had to rely..." is a relative clause and cannot stand alone, so the sentence must continue. "Unfortunately" is parenthetical: commas on both sides. (A) and (D) strand the relative clause as a fragment. (B) drops the opening comma, leaving the parenthetical unmarked.

25. Correct answer: A

A complete independent clause precedes the blank, and what follows is a list that specifies "three factors." A **colon** is the correct mark for introducing a list after a full clause. (B) a comma cannot introduce a list here. (C) a semicolon must join two independent clauses; a list is not one. (D) paired dashes require the interrupted sentence to resume, which it does not.

26. Correct answer: B

Punctuation marks that set off a supplement must **match**. A dash closes the interruption after "absolute zero," so a dash must open it. (A), (C), and (D) all mismatch the closing dash. *Key move:* whenever one dash or comma is already printed in the sentence, look for its partner before reading the choices.

27. Correct answer: B

The passage opens with "Because," making everything before the blank a **dependent** clause. A dependent clause placed before a main clause is joined to it with a comma. (A), (C), and (D) all treat the "Because" clause as though it could stand alone, producing a fragment.

28. Correct answer: C

Two independent clauses; "nevertheless" introduces the second. It needs a semicolon before it and a comma after it. (A), (B), and (D) all join the two clauses with nothing stronger than a comma — comma splices. *Key move:* "nevertheless," "however," "therefore," and "moreover" are **adverbs, not conjunctions**. They can never join two sentences with a comma alone.

Part 2B — Other punctuation and boundaries

29. Correct answer: C

"Who shared the 1963 Nobel Prize..." is a nonessential clause already closed by a comma after "structure." The opening mark must match: a comma. (D) leaves the supplement unpunctuated on one side. (A) and (B) mismatch the closing comma.

30. Correct answer: D

Never separate a subject from its verb with punctuation, however long the subject is. The subject is "studies" (plural), so "suggest" is correct and unpunctuated. (A) and (B) insert an illegal comma. (C) leaves the sentence without a main verb.

31. Correct answer: B

When the items in a list already contain internal commas, the items are separated by **semicolons**. The semicolon before "and La Paz" is already printed, confirming the pattern. (C) a comma is indistinguishable from the internal commas. (A) and (D) do not separate list items.

32. Correct answer: A

A **dash** is the standard mark for a summarizing clause that gathers up a preceding list. (B) a colon requires a complete independent clause before it; a bare list is not one. (C) likewise requires an independent clause on the left. (D) a comma leaves the list and the summary indistinguishable.

33. Correct answer: A

Two independent clauses joined by the coordinating conjunction "and" require a comma *before* the conjunction. (C) is a comma splice. (D) omits the required comma. (B) a semicolon and a coordinating conjunction are redundant; use one or the other.

34. Correct answer: B

"From four subarctic lakes" is an essential prepositional phrase modifying "collected." Nothing separates them. The most common error on this question type is assuming a blank must be filled. On the SAT, **no punctuation is frequently the right answer** — (A), (C), and (D) all interrupt a phrase that must stay intact.

Part 2C — Verbs, pronouns, modifiers, possessives

35. Correct answer: C

The subject is "array" (singular), not "sensors," which is merely the object of the preposition "of." Singular subject takes **records**. (B) and (D) are plural. (A) is plural and shifts the tense unnecessarily.

36. Correct answer: A

With "neither...nor," the verb agrees with the **nearer** subject. "Students" is plural, so **were**. (B), (C), and (D) are all singular. (C) also breaks the past-tense sequence set by "appeared."

37. Correct answer: C

The earlier expeditions preceded a point already in the past ("by the time... in 1953"), which calls for the **past perfect**: had come. (A) is present tense. (B) present perfect connects to now, not to 1953. (D) past progressive suggests ongoing action rather than completed prior events.

38. Correct answer: D

"Committee" is a singular collective noun, so the possessive is **its**. (A) "it's" is the contraction of *it is*. (B) is plural. (C) is a contraction of *they are* and is not possessive at all.

39. Correct answer: B

The pronoun is an object of the preposition "between," so it takes the **objective** case: her. (A) is subjective. (C) a reflexive requires an antecedent in the same clause. (D) is possessive. *Key move:* drop the other name — "the rivalry between her" — and the case becomes obvious.

40. Correct answer: D

The pronoun stands in for "routes," which is plural, so **those**. (B) and (C) are singular. (A) "them" cannot take the modifying phrase "of sooty shearwaters."

41. Correct answer: A

An opening participial phrase must modify the subject of the main clause. The thing that weighs less than a paperclip is the **bird**. (C) makes the *nest* the subject. (D) makes *researchers* weigh less than a paperclip. (B) makes *it* — an empty placeholder — the subject.

42. Correct answer: A

The **figures** lay buried for two thousand years, so "the wooden figures" must be the subject of the main clause. (D) says the archaeologists were buried. (B) says the excavation was buried. (C) says "it" was buried.

43. Correct answer: B

The person trained as a chemist is **Tu Youyou**, so she must be the subject. (A) makes *malaria* the trainee. (C) makes the placeholder *it* the subject. (D) is the sharpest distractor: *Tu Youyou's career* was not trained as a chemist — a possessive noun cannot serve as the modified subject.

44. Correct answer: B

"Both" and "their deaths" establish two owners, so the possessive is plural: **scientists'** — plural noun plus apostrophe. (C) is singular possessive. (D) is plural but not possessive. (A) is not a standard English form.

45. Correct answer: C

"Its displacement" later in the sentence establishes a single ship, so the singular possessive **vessel's** is required. (B) is a plural with no possessive marking. (D) is plural possessive, contradicting "its." (A) is not standard.

Part 2D — Transitions

46. Correct answer: B

The third sentence **intensifies and specifies** the general claim in the second — exactly the job of "in fact." (C) signals contrast, but there is none. (D) signals comparison to a parallel case, and none is offered. (A) is a time phrase, not a logical connector, and nothing in the passage marks a peak.

47. Correct answer: C

What happened **replaced** what was expected — the precise function of "instead." (D) claims similarity between an expectation and its violation. (A) claims the delay resulted from the expectation. (B) adds a parallel point rather than overturning one.

48. Correct answer: A

The third sentence draws a **consequence** from the chain established in the first two. (B) and (D) signal contrast, but the sentences agree. (C) signals a parallel example, and none is given.

Tutor notes — how to review this set

Reading the results diagnostically

Score Part 2A separately from everything else. If she misses four or more of those twelve, the issue is not punctuation knowledge — it is **clause identification**, and drilling comma rules will not fix it. Have her mark every subject and every finite verb in the passage before she reads a single answer choice.

The three traps built into Part 2A

1. The fragment trap (items 21, 22, 23, 24). The material after the blank looks like a new sentence but is actually a dependent clause — *only after...*, *precisely because...*, *which is why...*. Choosing "period + However," produces a fragment. The tell is a subordinating word (*after, because, which, if, although, since*) sitting right after the blank.

2. The two-adverb collision (item 19). Two transitional adverbs meet at the boundary, one closing the first clause and one opening the second. She must assign each adverb to its clause before punctuating. Reading the sentence aloud with a deliberate pause usually settles it.

3. The comma splice (items 17, 18, 19, 20, 28). Most of the wrong choices join two complete sentences with a comma. Because a conjunctive adverb *feels* like a conjunction, the splice reads smoothly and gets selected. Worth memorizing: *however, therefore, nevertheless, moreover, consequently, instead, indeed, otherwise* are adverbs. They cannot join sentences. Only *for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so* can, and only with a comma before them.

For the vocabulary items

When she misses one, ask which of two things went wrong: did she misread the *direction* of the passage (agreement vs. contrast), or did she read the direction correctly but not know the word? These require different fixes. Direction errors are a close-reading problem and respond to underlining the pivot word (*far from, rather than, though, once*). Word-knowledge gaps respond to a running list. Items 3, 7, 11, and 12 are deliberately built so that a plausible-sounding choice is defeated by direction alone — she can get those right without knowing every word.

Common near-misses to expect

Item 7 (*exacting* vs. *mercurial*), item 12 (*reticent* vs. *meticulous*), and item 15 (*heterodox* vs. *ubiquitous*) each have one distractor that describes something true about the passage but does not answer the question asked. That distinction — true but not responsive — is the main thing separating a 700-level reader from a 750-level one.